in 1999, a year after their respective nuclear tests, when the two countries fought a bitter border war in the icy heights of Kargil under the shadow of a nuclear umbrella. When both sides brandished their nukes, Clinton was forced to step in and tell Pakistan to withdraw its intrusion and restore status quo. The US had to intervene again after the 2001 terror attack on India's Parliament to prevent an all-out war between the two countries by forcing Pakistan to take strict action against terror.

The third nuclear confrontation took place as recently as February 2019, following the Pulwama terror attack that killed 40 paramilitary personnel, prompting India to send fighter jets to strike terrorist camps in Balakot, deep within Pakistani territory. However, when an Indian pilot was captured in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir after his fighter jet was shot down and he bailed out, the crisis, according to then US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo, came close "to spilling over into a nuclear conflagration". Pakistan accused India of moving its nuclear-armed submarine close to its shores and gave orders to keep its nukes in readiness. It took Pompeo and then US national security advisor John Bolton much jaw-jawing with leaders of the two sides to defuse the situation, with the pilot set free and both India and Pakistan claiming victory.

Dangerous Brinkmanship

Despite the sixth war between India and Pakistan lasting just four days compared to the two-month-long 1999 Kargil war, Lisa Curtis, director, Indo Pacific Security Program, Center for a New American Security, in Washington DC, believes it was the most serious Indo-Pak conflict since the 1971 Bangladesh war. Her reason: "The scope and breadth of the territory involved in this war was vast compared to the limited border strikes in the 1999 Kargil war. I have been following India-Pakistan now for 30 years and the sight of two nuclear-armed states barraging each other with missiles and drone strikes over a four-day period, striking military installations deep inside each other's territory, was both shocking and alarming."

From US vice-president J.D. Vance telling Fox News on May 8 that this conflict was none of America's business to calling up PM Modi 12 hours later, asking India to de-escalate, is how rapidly the situation had escalated. According to American media reports, Vance had conveyed to Modi on May 9 that, as per US assessment, there was a high probability of Pakistan dramatically escalating violence, and pressed the Indian premier for a potential off-ramp to stop hostilities that would also be acceptable to the Pakistanis. But while the reports said Modi was non-committal, sources in India's external affairs ministry reveal that the Indian prime minister told Vance, "If the Pakistanis do anything, please be assured that they will get a response more forceful, stronger and more devastating than anything they did. Pakistan needs to understand this."

THE NUKE BUTTON

Who is authorised to press it in India and Pakistan, under what circumstances, the defences both countries have to thwart nuke attacks, and incidents of near-misses in the past

NUCLEAR DOCTRINES

INDIA: 'NO FIRST USE' (NFU)

India's conditions for using its nuclear weapons are:

- It will use nuclear weapons only in response to a nuclear attack or a chemical/biological weapons (CBW) attack on Indian territory or on its armed forces
- Any nuclear/CBW first strike could trigger a massive punitive hit-back to 'inflict unacceptable damage' on the aggressor
- India will not use its weapons on non-nuclear power states or those that do not have protective nuclear umbrellas provided by other countries

PAKISTAN: 'FULL-SPECTRUM DETERRENCE'

Pakistan can use its nuke weapons if it faces the following threats:

- Spatial (any large loss of territory)
- Military (destruction/targeting of its armed forces)
- Economic (aggressive acts that could choke the economy)
- Political (acts that lead to political destabilisation)
- In any of the above situations, it can use the full spectrum of its nuclear arsenal, from tactical nukes to mass scale strategic nuclear weapons

Modi's warning went unheeded by Pakistan. That evening, around 8.30, its armed forces launched Operation *Bunyan Marsoos* (literally, a wall of lead, but a phrase that symbolises unity, strength and discipline), unleashing a wave of retaliatory strikes using drones, heavy artillery and missiles on 26 sensitive Indian locations, including air bases and military installations. It even launched a Fatah-II missile, a supersonic guided artillery rocket system with 400-km range, to strike the Delhi airport, but India's missile defence system intercepted it near Sirsa.